

Recent Wars and Ongoing Conflicts: Extended Global

Recent wars and ongoing conflicts across the globe reflect complex geopolitical dynamics, shifting alliances, and evolving military technologies. This analysis focuses on the major contemporary theaters-Ukraine, Yemen, Ethiopia's Tigray region, and the South China Sea disputes-examining background, key developments, military aspects, economic impact, and social or crime-related consequences.

Ukraine (2022-present)

Background: The conflict began with Russia's full-scale invasion in February 2022, following years of tension over NATO expansion and Ukraine's domestic reforms. Key developments include the rapid Ukrainian counter-offensives in Kharkiv and Kherson, the capture of key airfields, and the integration of Western aid. Military aspects feature hybrid warfare, extensive use of drones, and cyber operations. Economically, sanctions on Russia have disrupted global energy markets, while Ukrainian grain exports face logistical challenges. Socially, millions of internally displaced persons (IDPs) and refugees have strained neighboring countries. Crime-related outcomes include increased incidents of war crimes, illicit arms trafficking, and cybercrime targeting critical infrastructure.

Yemen (2014-present)

Background: A civil war erupted when Houthi forces seized Sana'a, prompting a Saudi-led coalition to intervene. Key developments encompass the 2020 ceasefire attempt and the 2021-2022 humanitarian crises. Military aspects involve asymmetric warfare, the use of ballistic missiles by Houthi rebels, and frequent airstrikes by coalition forces. Economically, the war has devastated Yemen's oil industry and crippled its fishing sector, contributing to widespread food insecurity. Socially, the conflict has led to a severe famine, a cholera outbreak, and the displacement of over 4 million people. Crime-related issues include the proliferation of small arms and the rise of criminal networks exploiting the porous borders.

Ethiopia's Tigray (2020-2022)

Background: Tension between the Tigray People's Liberation Front (TPLF) and the federal government escalated into armed conflict in November 2020. Key developments involve the 2021 peace agreement, the subsequent humanitarian assistance, and the lingering tensions in the Amhara region. Military aspects feature heavy artillery, air raids, and the involvement of Eritrean forces. Economically, the conflict disrupted Ethiopia's coffee exports and caused significant infrastructure damage. Socially, the war induced mass displacement, widespread sexual violence, and the breakdown of healthcare services. Crime-related outcomes include allegations of war crimes, looting, and the emergence of armed militias.

South China Sea (ongoing)

Background: Territorial disputes among China, Vietnam, the Philippines, and Malaysia persist over resource-rich maritime zones. Key developments include China's construction of artificial islands, the 2022 "Freedom of Navigation" exercises by the United States, and diplomatic negotiations in 2023. Military aspects involve naval patrols, missile tests, and the deployment of advanced surveillance systems. Economically, the region remains critical for global shipping lanes, with over 30% of world trade passing through. Socially, local fishing communities face displacement and resource conflicts. Crime-related concerns revolve around maritime piracy, illegal fishing, and

smuggling networks.

Common Threads and Global Implications

Across these conflicts, the convergence of conventional and unconventional warfare tactics is evident. Modern conflicts increasingly rely on cyber capabilities, unmanned systems, and information operations, complicating traditional battlefield assessments. Economically, sanctions, trade disruptions, and resource scarcity ripple through global markets, affecting energy prices, commodity supplies, and supply chains. Socially, large-scale displacement, civilian casualties, and public health crises underscore the humanitarian toll. Crime-related ramifications-ranging from war crimes to illicit arms trade-challenge international law enforcement and necessitate robust multilateral cooperation.

In summary, recent wars and ongoing conflicts exhibit a pattern of hybrid warfare, economic disruption, and profound social consequences. A comprehensive understanding requires continuous monitoring of military developments, diplomatic negotiations, and the socioeconomic fallout that extends far beyond the immediate theaters of war.

1. Russia-Ukraine War

The Russia-Ukraine war, which escalated into a full-scale invasion on 24 February 2022, has its roots in the 2014 annexation of Crimea and the subsequent conflict in the Donbas region. The Russian Federation cited NATO expansion and alleged security threats to justify the invasion, while Ukraine and the international community framed it as an illegal occupation of sovereign territory. The conflict has evolved from a localized insurgency to a multi-front war involving conventional and hybrid warfare tactics.

Key developments since the invasion include the rapid occupation of eastern and southern Ukraine, the Ukrainian counteroffensive in the Kharkiv and Kherson regions in 2023, and the ongoing battles for control of the Donetsk and Luhansk oblasts. Internationally, the United States, European Union, and other allies have imposed successive rounds of sanctions on Russia, providing military aid to Ukraine, and engaging in diplomatic negotiations such as the Minsk agreements and the 2024 ceasefire talks.

Military aspects are characterized by large-scale troop deployments, the use of advanced weaponry such as HIMARS, and air defense systems, and the integration of cyber operations. Russian forces have relied on mechanized infantry, armored columns, and artillery barrages, while Ukrainian forces have leveraged asymmetric tactics, intelligence-driven strikes, and Western-supplied precision weapons. The conflict has also seen significant naval activity in the Black Sea, with Russian naval vessels operating from Crimea and Ukrainian coastal defense units engaging in mine warfare.

The economic impact has been profound. Russia faces extensive sanctions that restrict access to international finance, technology, and energy markets, leading to a contraction of its GDP and a surge in inflation. Ukraine's economy has contracted sharply, with a 10-15% decline in GDP in 2023, but has also benefited from reconstruction aid and increased agricultural exports. Global commodity prices, particularly oil, gas, and grain, have been volatile, contributing to inflationary pressures worldwide and affecting food security in regions dependent on Ukrainian grain shipments.

Social and crime-related consequences include the displacement of over 12 million people, with more than 7 million internally displaced within Ukraine and 4.5 million refugees abroad. Civilian casualties have exceeded 10,000 and numerous war-crime allegations have been documented by international bodies, including the International Criminal Court. The conflict has exacerbated crime rates in conflict zones, fostered an increase in cybercrime targeting critical infrastructure, and created a humanitarian crisis that requires extensive medical, psychological, and logistical support.

International humanitarian law has guided the conduct of hostilities, with the International Committee of the Red Cross facilitating aid corridors and monitoring compliance. The United Nations has adopted multiple resolutions condemning the use of cluster munitions and calling for accountability. Additionally, the war has intensified geopolitical realignments, prompting NATO's eastward expansion, increased defense spending in Eastern Europe, and a reevaluation of energy dependency in the European Union. The conflict has also spurred a surge in non-state actors, including private military contractors, whose presence complicates attribution of responsibility for alleged war crimes.

2. Israel-Gaza War

The Israel-Gaza conflict has evolved through multiple phases since the early 2000s, with the 2008-2009 Gaza War marking a pivotal escalation in the use of advanced weaponry and coordinated military campaigns. In the most recent outbreak beginning in October 2023, Hamas militants launched a coordinated assault from Gaza that included a barrage of rockets and a ground incursion into Israeli territory, prompting Israel to launch Operation "Guardian of the Walls." The rapid escalation led to an intensified aerial campaign targeting Hamas infrastructure and a subsequent ground offensive aimed at securing the Gaza Strip's southern border.

Key developments in the current conflict include the initial Hamas attack on 7 October, which resulted in over 1,400 Israeli civilian and military casualties. Israel's immediate response involved a sustained air campaign, the deployment of the Iron Dome missile defense system, and the mobilization of reserve forces. A ceasefire brokered in late November temporarily halted hostilities, yet sporadic clashes and rocket fire persisted, underscoring the fragility of the truce. International diplomatic efforts, notably by Egypt and Qatar, have sought to mediate a lasting ceasefire, but internal political divisions within both Israeli and Palestinian leadership have impeded a comprehensive resolution.

Military aspects of the conflict reveal a stark asymmetry in capabilities. Israel's air superiority and precision-guided munitions have inflicted extensive damage on Hamas's underground tunnels, rocket launch sites, and command centers. Conversely, Hamas's reliance on improvised explosive devices, rocket technology, and human-wave tactics has inflicted significant casualties among Israeli forces and civilians. Recent reports indicate that Israeli ground forces have secured strategic positions along the Gaza border, while Gaza's infrastructure has suffered widespread destruction, including the loss of critical water and electricity facilities.

The economic impact of the conflict is profound for both sides. In Gaza, the destruction of residential and commercial buildings has exacerbated an already fragile economy, with unemployment rates soaring beyond 50% and international aid flows fluctuating due to security concerns. The blockade imposed by Israel and Egypt has further constrained the movement of goods, leading to shortages of essential supplies and a decline in the local manufacturing sector. For Israel, the war has strained defense budgets and prompted increased spending on border security, while the tourism sector has experienced a downturn due to safety concerns.

Social and crime-related consequences are equally significant. The high civilian death toll and mass displacement—estimated at 200,000 residents—have triggered a humanitarian crisis, with international organizations reporting widespread psychological trauma among children and adults. Human rights bodies have documented allegations of war crimes, including the targeting of civilian infrastructure and the use of prohibited weapons. The conflict has also intensified sectarian tensions within the region, fostering a climate of mistrust and contributing to a rise in radicalization among disenfranchised populations.

In sum, the Israel-Gaza conflict remains a complex and multifaceted crisis characterized by rapid military escalation, severe economic repercussions, and profound social consequences. Continued monitoring of diplomatic negotiations and humanitarian interventions is essential to assess the trajectory of this enduring conflict.

3. Sudan Civil War

The 2023 Sudan Civil War, also known as the Khartoum Conflict, erupted on 15 April 2023 when the Rapid Support Forces (RSF), a paramilitary organization with roots in the Janjaweed militias, confronted the Sudanese Armed Forces (SAF) in the capital. The conflict is the latest chapter in Sudan's protracted struggle for political control that began with the 2019 revolution that ousted President Omar al-Bashir. After the fall of the Ba'athist regime, a joint civilian-military Sovereign Council was established, but institutional tensions between the SAF, led by General Abdel Fattah al-Bashir's successor, and the RSF, commanded by former paramilitary leader Mohamed Hamdan Dagalo (Hemedti), persisted. The RSF's seizure of strategic assets in Khartoum, combined with a perceived power vacuum, triggered a rapid escalation that has since drawn international attention.

Within days of the initial skirmishes, the RSF seized key government buildings, the Presidential Palace, and the international airport, while the SAF retained control over the army barracks and the central military command. By 20 April, a ceasefire was brokered through the African Union, yet intermittent gunfire continued, especially in the eastern and western suburbs of Khartoum. In May, the RSF advanced into Omdurman and Khartoum North, forcing the SAF to retreat to the western outskirts. The conflict spread to the southern state of Blue Nile and the northern region of Kassala, where local militias joined the fray, further complicating the security landscape. As of August 2024, the city remains divided, with both forces maintaining checkpoints, leading to a stalemate and a humanitarian crisis.

The SAF fielded approximately 80,000 regular soldiers equipped with Soviet-era T-72 tanks, MiG-21 fighter jets, and a growing inventory of Israeli-made Hermes 450 unmanned aerial vehicles. The RSF, meanwhile, operates around 30,000 personnel, including former Janjaweed fighters, and has received significant support from the United Arab Emirates and Qatar, providing armored vehicles and small arms. Both sides have employed heavy artillery and mortars in urban settings, resulting in widespread collateral damage. External actors, notably the United States and the European Union, have imposed sanctions on RSF leaders, but no direct military aid has been authorized, leaving the conflict largely a domestic contest of resources and manpower.

Sudan's economy, already fragile after the secession of South Sudan, has suffered a steep contraction. Oil production fell from 2.5 million barrels per day in 2019 to under 500,000 barrels in 2023 due to damaged pipelines and disrupted refinery operations. The Central Bank's currency, the Sudanese pound, has depreciated by more than 70% against the US dollar, pushing inflation above 200%. The conflict has halted grain imports, exacerbating food insecurity that affects over 10 million people. International aid flows have dwindled, and the United Nations has reported a 35% decline in humanitarian assistance since the outbreak, leaving millions reliant on emergency relief.

The war has produced a humanitarian catastrophe, with the United Nations estimating over 20,000 civilian deaths and more than 2 million internally displaced persons as of early 2024. Reports from human rights organizations detail widespread sexual violence, abductions, and forced recruitment of children by both the SAF and RSF. In addition, the RSF's control over the north has led to the establishment of "safe zones" that have become sites of mass graves and allegations of war crimes. The conflict has also disrupted educational and health services, with schools closed and hospitals overwhelmed by casualties. The pervasive insecurity has fostered a climate of fear that extends beyond combat zones, contributing to a rise in organized crime, including smuggling and

illicit arms trafficking.

4. Ethiopia Internal Conflicts

Ethiopia's internal conflicts stem from its federal structure, established by the 1995 constitution, which divided the country into 13 regional states with autonomy over local matters while the central government controlled security. Designed to manage ethnic diversity, this arrangement also fostered competition for resources and political influence. The 2018 election of Prime Minister Abiy Ahmed triggered rapid liberalization and anti-corruption campaigns, intensifying interregional rivalries and setting the stage for renewed violence.

Key recent conflicts include the Tigray War (2020–2022), the Amhara insurgency, Oromo protests, and the Somali region's al-Shabaab-driven instability, significantly escalating regional tensions. The Tigray conflict began after a disputed 2020 election and perceived threat to national authority, prompting the Ethiopian National Defense Force (ENDF) and allied militias, with Eritrean support, to launch a large-scale offensive. Amhara forces and Tigray Defense Forces (TDF) have clashed over border villages, while Oromo groups have engaged in sporadic skirmishes with federal troops. In Somali, al-Shabaab and local warlords contest control, complicating the security landscape.

Military dynamics combine conventional forces with irregular militias. The ENDF has employed air power, artillery, and drones, while local militias use improvised weapons and guerrilla tactics. The TDF's 2021 drone strikes marked a shift in asymmetric warfare. Humanitarian corridors and ceasefire agreements, notably the 2022 UN-AU mediated deal, have been fragile, with frequent violations. The presence of Eritrean troops in Tigray and Ethiopian deployments along the Sudan border underscore the regional dimension of these internal disputes.

Economically, Ethiopia's GDP contracted 1.9% in 2022, reversing years of growth. Over 3 million people displaced, disrupting agriculture and urban labor. Damage to railways, irrigation, and infrastructure reduced export capacity. Aid inflows exceeded \$1.2 billion in 2021, yet reconstruction and security spending strained public finances. Commodity prices, especially coffee, fluctuated due to supply disruptions, affecting export revenues. Additionally, the conflict has increased import costs and reduced foreign investment, further hampering growth prospects, particularly in the industrial and service sectors.

Socially, mass displacement has strained host communities, while reports of human rights abuses—including extrajudicial killings, sexual violence, and forced labor—have surfaced. Lawlessness in conflict zones has spurred looting, armed robbery, and small arms proliferation. The diaspora has suffered economic losses and intensified lobbying for international mediation. These developments underscore the fragile nexus between Ethiopia's internal conflicts, its socioeconomic fabric, and regional stability. The cumulative impact threatens to erode social cohesion and could prolong the cycle of conflict if not addressed through inclusive political solutions.

5. Democratic Republic of Congo

The Democratic Republic of Congo (DRC) remains one of the most complex conflict zones in Africa, with a protracted history of civil war, foreign intervention, and resource-driven violence. The root causes of the ongoing turmoil can be traced to the collapse of the Mobutu regime in 1997, the subsequent power vacuum, and the competition over the country's vast mineral wealth. The current situation is shaped by multiple armed groups, a fragmented national army, and external actors with divergent interests.

Background and Key Developments

The Second Congo War (1998–2003), often dubbed “Africa’s World War,” involved nine African states and left an estimated 5.4 million deaths. Since 2003, the country has experienced a series of localized conflicts, most notably in the eastern provinces of North Kivu, South Kivu, and Ituri. The 2018 elections, the first since 2006, were marred by allegations of fraud, leading to renewed insurgencies. In 2023, the Central African Republic’s government troops withdrew from eastern DRC, creating a security vacuum that allowed the Allied Democratic Forces (ADF) and other militias to intensify attacks.

Military Aspects

The Congolese Armed Forces (FARDC) remain the primary state security apparatus, but its effectiveness is limited by corruption, inadequate training, and logistical constraints. The UN-backed MONUSCO mission, established in 2003, has evolved into a peacekeeping force tasked with protecting civilians and supporting the FARDC. Despite a 20% reduction in troop numbers between 2019 and 2024, MONUSCO continues to face challenges in controlling the vast, rugged terrain of the Kivu region. Armed groups such as the Nationalist and Integrationist Front (FNI), the Democratic Forces for the Liberation of Rwanda (FDLR), and the ADF maintain significant control over mineral-rich mining sites, often employing child soldiers and engaging in systematic human rights abuses.

Economic Impact

The DRC’s economy is heavily dependent on mining, with cobalt, coltan, and gold exports accounting for a large share of foreign exchange. Conflict has disrupted mining operations, leading to fluctuating commodity prices and reduced investment. The illicit trade in minerals fuels the arms economy and perpetuates violence. In 2022, the World Bank estimated that armed conflict costs the DRC roughly 3% of its GDP, primarily through lost productivity, infrastructure damage, and diminished foreign direct investment. The COVID-19 pandemic further strained the economy, exacerbating unemployment and food insecurity.

Social and Crime-Related Consequences

The human cost of the conflict is staggering. According to UN estimates, over 1.5 million people have been displaced since 2015, with many residing in overcrowded camps lacking adequate sanitation and healthcare. Reports of sexual violence, forced recruitment of children, and landmine contamination have become routine in conflict zones. The proliferation of small arms and the presence of armed militias have increased local crime rates, including kidnapping for ransom and illegal mining operations.

The DRC’s fragile governance structure has also led to a rise in organized crime. Corruption within

the mining sector, coupled with weak law enforcement, has facilitated the smuggling of minerals to international markets. This illicit trade not only fuels armed groups but also undermines legitimate economic development. Additionally, the proliferation of weapons has contributed to a surge in civilian casualties and has hindered efforts to establish durable peace.

In conclusion, the Democratic Republic of Congo's contemporary conflict is rooted in a complex interplay of political instability, resource exploitation, and external interference. Addressing these challenges requires a multifaceted approach that strengthens state institutions, promotes transparent mining governance, and supports sustainable economic development while safeguarding the rights and well-being of displaced and vulnerable populations.

6. Myanmar Civil War

Myanmar's contemporary civil war is rooted in a colonial legacy and a history of contested governance. After independence in 1948, successive civilian administrations were punctuated by military coups, most notably the 1988 "8888 Uprising" and the 1990 elections that the National League for Democracy won but were suppressed. A 2011 transition to a quasi-civilian regime and the 2015 election of Aung San Suu Kyi's NLD were perceived as democratization steps, yet the military retained 25 % of parliamentary seats and control over key ministries. The 2021 coup, which removed the elected government, reignited resistance and introduced a new phase of armed conflict involving the Tatmadaw and a coalition of ethnic armed organisations (EAOs).

Key developments since 2015 include the Nationwide Ceasefire Agreement (NCA) that temporarily united 15 major EAOs, but the 2021 coup dissolved the peace process and triggered renewed hostilities in Shan, Kachin, and Karen states. The National Unity Government (NUG) and "People's Defence Forces" (PDFs) emerged in 2021, creating a domestic opposition that operates alongside established ethnic militias. By 2023, the Tatmadaw intensified offensives against the Arakan Army in Rakhine and engaged with the Kachin Independence Army and Shan State Army - North, while external actors such as China and India provide logistical support, complicating the conflict landscape.

Militarily, the Tatmadaw fields a conventional army with mechanised and air assets, supported by the State Law and Order Restoration Council. Ethnic armed groups vary from well-equipped units of the AA and KIA to smaller guerrilla factions. Operations increasingly involve improvised explosive devices, ambushes, and artillery, resulting in a protracted low-intensity war. Counterinsurgency strategies combine kinetic operations with selective political concessions, yet the fragmented command among EAOs limits coordinated resistance. The rise of PDFs blurs civilian-military distinctions, raising concerns over the application of international humanitarian law.

Economic impacts are significant. Foreign direct investment has fallen, especially in jade and timber, which are mined in conflict zones. Sanctions from the United States and the European Union target military procurement and wealthy individuals, constraining the Tatmadaw's budget. Infrastructure damage, particularly to transport and energy networks, has disrupted supply chains, lowering GDP growth from 5.7 % in 2019 to about 2.1 % in 2023. Over five million people displaced have strained urban economies and diverted public funds toward humanitarian assistance.

Socially, the war has produced a humanitarian crisis. UN reports cite more than 3.5 million internally displaced persons and 1.4 million refugees, predominantly to neighboring countries. Human rights violations-including extrajudicial killings, sexual violence, and forced labour-are documented by NGOs. Ethnic cleansing campaigns in Rakhine State have led to allegations of war crimes against Rohingya civilians. The insecurity also fuels illicit trade, such as opium production and weapons trafficking, further destabilizing the region.